

The Stationery Worker – Burkean Parlor Submission — 2.28.26

There is a little cat on the cover of his journal. The cat wears a top hat that hides its face, and a pink derp tongue emerges from its whiskered mouth.

When the stationery worker bought the journal, he thought Derp Cat was cute. But over time, he has come to see Derp Cat as a representation of himself. He knows he can be quite silly like this cat's derp tongue. And he knows he can be quite shy, hiding his metaphorical "face" behind his metaphorical "top hat."

The stationery worker had the journal for two years before his friends started losing their virginity, and then Derp Cat acquired a whole new meaning. Derp Cat became a symbol of the stationery worker's inherent unfuckability and lack of love. After all, who wants to have sex with a Human Derp Cat?

The door to the store opens, and a man stumbles in, breathing heavily. The Man is tall and square-jawed, a few years older than the stationery worker, and wearing a white compression shirt that hugs his chest. Earbuds spill from The Man's pocket, grazing his upper thigh which is wet from perspiration.

At first, the stationery worker believes The Man is having a heart attack because of his pained expression.

"Sir? Are you okay?"

The Man's upper thigh convulses. He winces and leans against the wall, gritting his teeth, meeting eyes with the stationery worker.

"Cramp."

The stationery worker doesn't know what to say. He watches The Man's thigh twitch, and he watches the white teeth grit. Between the spasms, The Man and the stationery worker make brief eye contact. Each time, The Man forces out a breathless laugh, and the stationery worker puffs out air.

"Fuck me..."

The Man shoves his thumbs into the throbbing flesh. The stationery worker finds himself wanting to bite into the mass.

The spasm subsides, and The Man looks up at the stationery worker with a grin.

"Sorry, that was intense."

The stationery worker is stupefied by The Man's beauty and mentally flagellates himself: *Speak, you fool.*

"Maybe you're dehydrated."

"Why would I be dehydrated?"

"I heard muscle spasms happen because you're dehydrated."

"Not all the time."

"Well they sell water bottles next door."

"Are you trying to get me to leave?"

"No."

"Because I would understand. I'm dripping sweat all over. I probably stink."

Indeed, The Man's smell has filled the little stationery shop, mingling with the incense. Underneath the sandalwood sweet, there is the spice of musk. The stationery worker finds the smell primitive. He imagines The Man's pheromones sticking to his nose hairs like flecks of gold, entering his brain, and sending blood down to his groin.

The stationery worker surprises himself.

"I don't mind the smell."

Immediately, the stationary's cheeks burn and he wishes he could kill himself. The Man gives the stationery worker a quizzical look.

"What'd you say?"

"I was... It was a joke."

The Man looks down at the flecks of sweat around his sneakers.

"You should come lick it, then."

The stationary worker's heart races.

"What?"

"Come lick my sweat off the floor."

"Are you... Are you serious?"

The Man laughs.

"No. You freak."

Then the man winks at him.

"Your eyebrows are hot. Maybe I'll see you tomorrow."

The Man leaves the store, breaking into a sprint down the sidewalk.

The stationery worker shudders like a leaf in a breeze. The Man's sweat tinkles on the floor, and the stationery worker imagines stripping off his clothes and rolling around in it. Then the stationery worker makes eye contact with Derp Cat and mops the sweat up with a broom instead.

That night, the stationery worker looks at his eyebrows in the mirror. He has never noticed his eyebrows before, but now he sees how they could be considered "hot." They are thick and well-shaped. Like two brown check marks. The stationery worker chalks them up to his Middle Eastern heritage and feels grateful. He wishes that his father were alive. He wishes he could call his father and say, "Thank you for my eyebrows. They made me happy today."

The stationery worker put on his best jeans and combed back his long hair to show off his eyebrows.

"Why are these pens so expensive?"

The Man is sweating again, and his shorts are shorter.

"They're fountain pens. You refill them with ink."

"Who wants to refill their pen?"

"Some people like rituals."

"Refilling ink is a ritual?"

"It imbues the mundane with meaning."

"It imbues the mundane with meaning."

Is The Man mocking him? The stationery worker grows defensive.

"Well, it does."

"I think that people who do that probably don't have much excitement in their life."

"I have plenty of excitement in my life."

They stare at one another.

Then they are kissing, eating each other's mouths, and The Man pushes the stationery worker against the wall of the storage room. It is all happening so fast. Bursts of colorful sensation splattering across the stationery worker's consciousness. How he has gone without this for twenty years, he does not know. The Man seems to know all his baser instincts. The Man does this thing to the stationery worker that is very similar to the stationery worker's first sexual experience in the seventh grade, when his best friend drew pineapples on his lower back. The stationery worker takes this as a sign that The Man is his Soulmate. The stationery worker thinks that The Universe has finally sent him a source of happiness after many years of grief, isolation, and otherness.

The Man pulls back and asks for permission. The duality of The Man astonishes the stationery worker further. The Man takes what he wants, but he also asks permission. The stationery worker can't believe The Man wants him. But it's happening. Being Wanted. It's happening. To the stationery worker.

Then it is over. The Man collapses, and the stationery worker collapses with him. The stationery worker's journal falls out of the jeans around his ankles, and he curls up into The Man, practically humming with pleasure.

The Man heaves, smiling down at the stationery worker.

"Hot eyebrows."

And licks his eyebrows.

The stationery worker laughs.

They are happy together.

The Man sees the stationery worker's journal on the floor and picks it up.

"This yours?"

"I write in it with my *refillable fountain pen*."

"What's this weird cat on the cover?"

"That's Derp Cat. Don't call him weird."

"Why can't I call him weird?"

The stationary workers says nothing.

The Man pokes him.

"Oh, *now* you're being shy?"

The stationery worker stands. He decides that if he is going to tell The Man about Derp Cat, he will need to do it dressed.

"After my dad died, I got hired at the stationery store, and I saw the the journal and laughed. I hadn't laughed for a very long time before that. I wrote about my dad's death in the journal, and adressed it to Derp Cat. It made me feel better."

The stationery worker pulls up his jeans. He can feel the words pouring out of him, cresting from his stomach to his esophogus like a wave.

"Then my friends started losing their virginity. Everyone was having sex and falling in love except for me. I wrote about it in the journal, and it made me feel better."

The stationery worker buttons up his shirt, feeling the freedom of the words, of the self-expression, of saying vulnerable things to another human.

"But now I am tired of writing in the journal. I want to live. I want to talk to people, not write to a fake cat. So I am glad I met you. I'm glad you got the cramp and came into the store. I am grateful."

The stationery worker finishes buttoning up his shirt and turns around, but The Man is gone, and he has taken the journal with him.